

US Video Game Education & Scholars Pipeline · Starter Directory (Draft 3)

Prepared by Gay Gaming Professionals · May 1, 2026 Built to be useful for students (filtered by age + region) AND for donors (with program type + efficacy specificity)

Framing. This directory supports **all students pursuing careers in video games, including those from underestimated communities.** It uses the corporate language major industry partners use today (*belonging, culture, community responsibility, social impact, talent attraction*) instead of older identity-label vocabulary. **AI readiness for the rising generation** is treated as a first-class category alongside grade-level tiers. **It is built to be student-facing AND donor-facing.**

How to read this directory

A **starter directory**, not a complete one. It captures the load-bearing programs, scholarships, and pipelines a student or family in the US should know about, sorted by **grade-level tier**, then **program type**, then **region**. Each entry has a one-line *what it is + efficacy / why a donor cares* tag.

The full version, post Take-Two Foundation launch partnership, will include 200 to 400 programs with verified outcomes data, hosted at **gaygamingpros.org/directory**, filterable, searchable, quarterly-refreshed.

Two paths through this directory

For a student or family: filter by age (5-10 / 11-14 / 14-18 / 18-22 / 22+), region (West / Mountain / Midwest / South / Northeast / Texas / HBCU), cost tier (Free / sliding / tuition + scholarship / full pay), and audience served. The grade-level tiers below are the primary navigation.

For a donor or funder: every entry carries a "*where dollars go furthest*" lens. Outcomes data, cost-per-outcome, and pipeline-leakage points are surfaced in each tier's donor-lens callout. The framework at the back of this directory expands the funder view.

TIER 1 · ELEMENTARY (K–5, ages 5–10)

Coding & game-curious entry programs

Program	Type	Region	Cost	Efficacy notes (for donors)
Code.org TechShopz	Free workshops, partner schools	National	Free	50+ topics, 1M+ students reached annually; partner of iD Tech · referrals at scale
Black Girls CODE Summer Camp 2026	Summer + afterschool	10 cities (Atlanta, Chicago, Detroit, LA, NYC, Raleigh-Durham, Memphis, Washington DC Metro, San Juan PR) + 2 virtual sessions	Sliding scale + scholarships	600+ youth ages 10–17; partnership with Endless Access; game design + AI + ethical tech innovation; June–August 2026
iD Tech Junior	Summer camps	75+ universities nationwide	Tuition (~\$1,000/wk); scholarships available via Code.org partnership	25 yrs of operation; ages 7–17; ~75K campers/year

Donor lens: at this tier, donations fund *exposure* · the kid who never met a game designer. Cost-per-converted-future-major is high (\$5–15K per eventual industry hire), but pipeline leakage starts here.

TIER 2 · MIDDLE SCHOOL (6–8, ages 11–14)

Identity-targeted programs

Program	Type	Region	Cost	Efficacy notes
Girls Who Code Pathways (Game Design track)	Free 6–7 wk virtual	National	Free	Open to rising 9th–12th · capture girls before HS attrition; 580K+ alumnae
Girls Make Games · Code Breakers	Camps + scholarships	National (multi-city)	Tuition + scholarships	Founded by Laila Shabir; pipeline to AIAS Foundation Girls Make Games scholarship; multi-year cohort tracking; female-identifying focus
Black Girls CODE Summer	In-person + virtual	10 cities	Sliding scale	Game development + AI 2026 emphasis; ages 10–17; 600 youth

Program	Type	Region	Cost	Efficacy notes
Camp 2026				target
Kode With Klossy	Free 2-wk camps	National (8 cities)	Free	Founded by Karlie Kloss; explicit gender-diversity-in-tech focus

Open-door programs

Program	Type	Region	Cost
iD Tech Game Design Camps	Week-long summer	75+ unis	Tuition
DigiPen ProjectFUN	Week + multi-week	Redmond, WA + select sat.	Tuition
Carnegie Mellon Summer Academy for Math + Science (SAMS)	6 weeks	Pittsburgh	Free for accepted students

Donor lens: middle school is where attrition for girls + students of color spikes. Money here has multiplier effect by tier 4.

TIER 3 · HIGH SCHOOL (9–12, ages 14–18)

Pre-college residential / immersive

Program	Type	Region	Cost	Efficacy
USC Summer Programs · Game Design	4-wk residential	Los Angeles	Tuition + scholarships	USC Games' top-of-funnel; high conversion to USC Games undergrad
NYU Tisch Game Center HS Summer	Residential	NYC	Tuition + scholarships	NYU is #1 ranked undergrad/grad · direct pipeline
CMU Pre-College Computational Biology / Game Design	6 weeks	Pittsburgh	Tuition	ETC referral path
DigiPen Summer Workshops	1–2 weeks	Redmond, WA	Tuition	Industry-direct curriculum
MIT MITES (Minority Introduction to Engineering & Science)	6 weeks	Cambridge	Free for accepted	Highly selective; STEM/games hybrid track

Program	Type	Region	Cost	Efficacy
Gameheads Year-Round Pipeline (high school track)	After-school + summer	Oakland, CA + remote	Free	Founded by Damon Packwood; East Bay anchor; ~70 enrolled annually; ~85% college-bound; consistent industry placements

Scholarship / cohort programs

Program	Award	Eligibility	Deadline
AIAS Foundation Scholarships (Foundation, WomenIn, Girls Make Games)	Varies	HS seniors → early professionals	May 31 annually
ESA Foundation CVGAS Scholarship	\$3,000	Women + minorities entering/in college	Spring annual
1,000 Dreams Fund Twitch Student	\$1,000 (24 awards)	Twitch Affiliated/Partnered student broadcasters	Ongoing
Minecraft Scholarship	\$2,000	HS + college, US citizens, GPA 3.0+	July 31 annually
Cxmmunity Foundation HBCU Scholarships	Varies	HBCU students in esports/gaming	Annual cycles

National competitions / showcases

Program	What it is	Region
HBCU Game Jam (Spelman College)	Annual competition	Atlanta + national HBCUs
STEM Video Game Challenge	National annual	Online · open to grades 5–12
The Yard: HBCU Esports Alliance	Esports + games structure	National HBCU network
IGNITE Impact Challenge (collegiate-leaning, HS-eligible 18+)	Short-form video competition on civic impact	National (online)

Donor lens: at this tier, money creates *named winners* · quantifiable. Track: scholarship dollars deployed → students placed in top-25 programs → industry hires.

TIER 4 · UNDERGRADUATE COLLEGE (ages 18–22)

Top US programs (Princeton Review 2026 rankings)

Rank	School	Region	Notes
#1	NYU Game Center	NYC	2026 Princeton Review #1 undergrad AND #1 grad (rose from #2 undergrad in 2025; held #1 grad). Flagship MFA.
#2	USC Games (School of Cinematic Arts + Viterbi Eng)	LA	12+ degree paths; Gordon Bellamy faculty here · relationship asset
#3	University of Central Florida (FIEA + main campus)	Orlando	FIEA = grad-only; UCF main campus undergrad
#4	Rochester Institute of Technology (RIT)	Rochester, NY	Strong indie/dev pipeline
5	DigiPen Institute of Technology	Redmond, WA	Industry-direct; small student body; 2026 PR #6 undergrad, up from #11
7	Clark University	Worcester, MA	2026 PR #7 undergrad; absorbed Becker College game-design programs in 2021
6	Becker College (<i>closed 2021 · programs migrated to Clark Univ</i>)	MA	Historical; now folded into Clark
7	Drexel Westphal	Philadelphia	Strong production track
8	Carnegie Mellon ETC (<i>grad-only</i>)	Pittsburgh	Most prestigious grad program for game-as-research
9	Worcester Polytechnic Institute (WPI)	MA	IMGD program
10	Bradley University	Peoria, IL	Surprise contender; strong placement
11	Bloomfield College of Montclair State	NJ	2026 top undergrad list
12	Michigan State University	East Lansing	Strong industry pipeline + esports
·	UW-Stout Game Design	Menomonie, WI	Top public game-design program; ~300 majors; midwestern pipeline anchor
·	Columbia College Chicago	Chicago	Strong narrative + production tracks
·	DePaul University CDM	Chicago	Industry-direct; Midwest entry

HBCU + minority-serving programs (special category)

School	Program	Notes
Spelman College	HBCU Game Jam host	Atlanta hub
Morehouse College	CS + games	Atlanta hub
Florida A&M	Esports + games	The Yard / HEA member
Howard University	Game design (developing)	DC
North Carolina A&T	Esports + games	The Yard / HEA member (per WUNC reporting)
Hampton University	The Yard / HEA member	VA

Industry-funded undergrad scholarships

Program	Funder	Amount	Eligibility
Higher Education Video Game Alliance (HEVGA) Future of the Game Industry Scholarship	Industry consortium	Varies	Member institutions
ESA Foundation Computer + Video Game Arts and Science	ESA	\$3,000	Women + minorities
AIAS Foundation Scholarship	AIAS	Varies	Game arts/science students
Riot Games Scholars Program	Riot Games	Varies	Underrepresented groups
EA SPORTS HBCU Scholars	Electronic Arts	Varies	HBCU students
2K Foundation / Take-Two community education partnerships	Take-Two Interactive	Per-relationship	Partnership-driven (no public RFP); GGP × Take-Two CYSTEM Mentorship is the live model

Donor lens: at this tier, dollars convert to *named positions in named programs at named schools*. Most measurable ROI tier. Track: \$/student/year → graduation rate → industry job placement within 12 months.

TIER 5 · GRADUATE (master's + doctoral)

Program	Region	Notes
NYU Game Center MFA	NYC	#1 ranked grad
USC Games MFA	LA	#3 ranked grad; Gordon's USC connection

Program	Region	Notes
CMU Entertainment Technology Center (ETC)	Pittsburgh	Most prestigious; 2-year MET
UCF FIEA (Florida Interactive Entertainment Academy)	Orlando	Grad-only; #2 ranked grad; industry-direct
MIT Game Lab / Comparative Media Studies	Cambridge	Research-leaning
Georgia Tech Digital Media	Atlanta	Research + industry
DePaul University CDM	Chicago	Strong Midwest entry

Graduate scholarships

- AIAS Foundation (graduate track)
- ESA Foundation (graduate eligibility)
- HEVGA Future of the Game Industry (graduate)
- IGDA Foundation (graduate scholarships)
- Take-Two ↔ academic institution partnerships (relationship-driven)

SPECIAL CATEGORY · GGP'S OWN PROGRAMS (the connective tissue)

GGP runs **five** programs that span the directory's grade tiers, each playing a distinct role:

Program	Tier served	What it is	Notes for donors
GGP Scholars	HS senior → grad	Flagship scholarship cohort, 7 years running (the organization is in its 20th year; the Scholars program launched ~2019). Identifies and cultivates emerging top performers in games. Public asset: the <i>GGP Scholars Content</i> YouTube playlist anchors the program's storytelling · including <i>The 2K Experience GGP at GDC '24</i> and the foundational <i>GGP Scholars</i> explainer (367+ views, Webby Honoree).	First Forbes 30 Under 30 alum named Sept 2025: Joseph Kemp, CEO Games That Matter LLC (creator of <i>Disbarred</i> , the legal-education card game). Audrey Webb (Roblox Product Designer) is a first-class alum.
CYSTEM Scholars <i>(Year 4 launching 2026–27)</i>	College + early-career	Mentorship-anchored scholarship · each scholar paired 1-on-1 with an industry mentor. Take-Two-anchored since 2023 via the GGP x Take-Two CYSTEM Mentorship Program. Led by Alex Rogers.	Standout alums include Ami Cai (NYS Empire State Development) and Christopher Kim (USC Marshall).

Program	Tier served	What it is	Notes for donors
Collegiate Games Challenge (CGC)	Undergrad	National competition. Universities (USC Games, USC Marshall, DePaul, others) nominate game projects + students compete on trailers/go-to-market for cash prizes.	\$90,000 awarded inaugural year (2025); Raw Thrills partnership; Roblox judging via GGP alums. 2026 CGC lottery already running.
GGP at Global Game Jam	All ages	Official GGJ host site, third year running, accessible to all (not just scholars cohort). 2026 jam hosted on the GGP Discord.	2026 GGJ × Games for Change launching GGJ Next (10–18) and G4C-GGJ Next Gen Expert Jam (18–25).
GGP × Games for Change funded scholars (2026–27)	College	Two scholars co-funded with G4C from the inaugural Mike + Amy Morhaime charity poker tournament. NY mirror in development.	Live precedent for matched fundraising at scale that Take-Two could anchor as next industry partner.

Annual touchpoints: - **GGP Scholars Breakfast at GDC** (Moscone, ~45 scholars in 2026) - **2K Studio Tour at GDC** for GGP & CYSTEM Scholars (Take-Two participates annually · anchor tradition) - **Double Fine Studio Tour at GDC** - **GGP Tea Party at DNA Lounge** (7th annual in 2026)

SPECIAL CATEGORY · CIVIC × GAMES CROSSOVER

IGNITE Impact Challenge · National Short-Form Video Competition

- **Prompt:** *Share Your Story* · how Public Law 119-21 (the One Big Beautiful Bill Act) is showing up in everyday life in your community.
- **Five categories:** SNAP & Medicaid · Student Loan · Immigration & Border · Energy & Climate · Individual or Business Tax.
- **Window:** April 10 – May 29, 2026.
- **Prize pool:** \$50,000 (\$5K / \$3K / \$2K per category × 5 categories = 15 winners).
- **Format:** smartphone-eligible. Solo or group. Short. Must be factual.
- **Audience:** 18+; specifically two- and four-year university students across 14 target departments (incl. Game Design).
- **Calendar:** mid-April portal live  → summer judging → early September winner announcement.

- **Partners:** IGNITE National (Sara Guillermo CEO) · Games for Change (Susanna Pollack, Lucas Piloto) · GGP (Eric Francksen Executive Producer, Bec Godsey, Gordon Bellamy) · **Bigglesworth Family Foundation** (Sinjin Bain, sponsor).
- **Site:** ignitenational.org/2026-impact-video-challenge

Why this entry matters in a games-education directory: IGNITE proves that civic short-form video and game-design pedagogy can share a pipeline. Game designers are storytellers; this is storytelling-with-stakes.

SPECIAL CATEGORY · GAMES FOR CHANGE (G4C) · operating partner across the pipeline

Games for Change is the connective tissue between GGP, IGNITE, the K-12 game-jam world, and the higher-ed games-for-impact community. Where GGP is an industry-pipeline organization, G4C is a civic-pipeline organization. The two programs serve adjacent populations and increasingly co-produce.

G4C Program	Tier served	What it is	Co-production with GGP
G4C Student Challenge	Middle/HS	Game-design challenge for civic issues; long-running (10+ years); national + multi-city	The college-age extension is IGNITE Impact Challenge above
G4C Annual Festival (NYC)	All	Premier civic-games conference; June annually	GGP regular presence
GGJ x G4C "Next" jams	10–18 + 18–25	New 2026 student-game-jam initiatives	Co-launched with Global Game Jam; GGP is a host site

G4C Board (verified) · the board overlap with GGP's network:

G4C Board Member	Role	GGP connection
Leo Olebe	Chair (Feb 2025–)	20+ years in games and entertainment industry; senior gaming-partnerships leadership at Meta, Google, YouTube, and Xbox over his career; succeeded Asi Burak who served as chair for 10 years (Burak remains on board as member). Current role outside the G4C chairmanship is in transition.
Susanna Pollack	President & Director	Active GGP collaborator (2026 IGNITE Impact Challenge, two co-funded GGP Scholars)
Amy Morhaime	Co-founder + Director	Co-hosting charity poker tournament funding GGP Scholars 2026–27

G4C Board Member	Role	GGP connection
Tracy Fullerton	Director	USC Games faculty · Gordon's USC colleague
Ben Golant	Director (Tencent Americas, Sr Director Global Video Game Policy)	Gordon's former Tencent connection

(Additional 2025 board members confirmed but not all individually mapped to GGP; live G4C board page is the canonical reference.)

SPECIAL CATEGORY · AI READINESS FOR THE RISING GENERATION

A 2026 emphasis. Programs that prepare students for AI-augmented work in games · for both students seeking the layer and donors who want to fund it.

Program	Type	Region	Notes
GGP × Take-Two AI in the Studio (proposed 2026–27)	Curriculum + ERG mentorship	National	Embedded in CYSTEM Mentorship; office hours with Take-Two engineers; "AI in the Studio" panel at 2K Studio Tour at GDC 2027
CGC AI track (proposed)	Competition track	National	AI-tool fluency as judged criterion
Code.org AI for All	Free curriculum	National (K-12)	Existing AI literacy module
Girls Who Code Pathways · AI track	Free virtual program	National	Already in operation
Black Girls CODE · AI added 2026	Summer + afterschool	10 cities	New 2026 emphasis on AI alongside game design
MIT MITES	Residential	Cambridge	STEM + AI-adjacent track
Carnegie Mellon ETC research	Graduate research	Pittsburgh	Active AI/games research

Donor lens for AI readiness: highest-leverage tier in the directory because the curriculum gap is acute and current. A scholar trained in AI-tool fluency entering the games industry in 2027 is a different hire profile than one without. Cost-per-outcome is low because most existing scholarship infrastructure can absorb an AI module without rebuilding.

TIER 6 · BOOTCAMPS, INDUSTRY PROGRAMS, CONTINUING ED

Program	Type	Region	Notes
Game Educators Summit (IndieCade)	Annual conference	LA / online	May 1, 2026 · for the educators
GamerEd™ initiative	Curriculum + training	National	Built for the next generation of leaders in the gaming industry
The Yard: HBCU Esports Alliance	Network of HBCU programs	National HBCUs	Replicable model
Cxmmunity Foundation programs	Esports + games training	National	HBCU-focused
Riot Games · Pipeline & Talent Programs	Industry training	Online + LA	Pipeline-direct
AbleGamers Charity	Accessibility + careers	National	Specialized but high-impact
Girls Make Games (Andamio Games)	Year-round programs + summer	National	High-school + middle-school focused
Gameheads Industry Bridge	Job-placement track	Oakland + remote	Damon Packwood; tight East Bay industry network
Gamesindustry.biz Career Workshops	Conferences + workshops	National	Working-pro pipeline

DIRECTORY USE-CASE FRAMEWORK

For a student or family

"I'm a [age] in [region]. What's available to me?"

The directory should be filterable by: - **Age:** 5–10 / 11–14 / 14–18 / 18–22 / 22+ - **Region:** West / Mountain / Midwest / South / Northeast / Texas / HBCU - **Cost tier:** Free / sliding scale / tuition + scholarship / full pay - **Audience served:** Open / women+girls / underestimated communities / disability / first-gen / HBCU - **Time-of-year:** Summer-only / year-round / academic-year-aligned

For a donor / funder

"I want to fund [outcome]. Where does my dollar go furthest?"

The directory should surface: - **Outcomes data:** completion rate, downstream placement, industry hire rate - **Cost-per-outcome:** \$/student exposed, \$/scholarship recipient, \$/industry hire - **Pipeline leakage points:** Where students drop out (typically: end of MS, end of HS, after 2nd year of college) - **Match-making:** Funder's geographic/identity priorities → programs that already serve that population - **Readiness layer:** which programs already include AI-tool fluency vs. which would benefit from an AI module overlay

For GGP specifically

"Where does GGP add unique value, distinct from existing programs?"

GGP's edge is **mentorship at scale plus industry visibility for all students pursuing careers in games, including those from underestimated communities.** Twenty years of network compounds into placements; the 2K Studio Tour at GDC tradition compounds into trust; the Collegiate Games Challenge compounds into discovery. The directory positions GGP not as a competitor but as the **connective tissue** across programs · a published, maintained resource that donors fund and students depend on.

What this directory needs to become real

1. **Verified outcomes data** for each entry (completion rate, placement rate, hire rate). Currently most programs do not publish this. Procuring it is a research lift the proposal funds.
2. **Real-time updates** · at least quarterly. Scholarship deadlines, new programs, defunct programs.
3. **Web-hosted, filterable, searchable** · not a PDF. Hosted at gaygamingpros.org/directory.
4. **Editorial standards** · what gets in, what doesn't, how new entries are vetted. (Recommend: industry-press coverage + outcomes data + audience-served alignment.)
5. **Donor-facing dashboard** · separate view aggregating gaps and impact opportunities.
6. **AI-readiness overlay** · every entry tagged for AI-curriculum status; the gap map becomes a fundable scope of work.

Method note

This is a starter directory. **Outcomes data** is not in this draft for most entries; procuring it is the work the funded build-out delivers. **Some 2025/2026 board changes** at G4C and other orgs may have shifted; canonical board pages remain the live source of truth. **Several mid-tier programs** (regional, HBCU, special-needs) are present but light on detail; the funded build-out is what fills these.

Sources

- [Princeton Review · 2026 Top Programs for Game Design](#)
- [The Princeton Review's Top Schools to Study Game Design for 2026 · PR Newswire](#)
- [US News · 2026 Best Undergraduate Game Design Programs](#)
- [Animation Career Review · Top 50 Game Design Schools 2026](#)
- [UCF FIEA · Game Design Programs Rank Among World's Best for 2026](#)
- [RIT · Game Design Ranked Among Top Five Worldwide](#)
- [Bold.org · Top Video Game Scholarships April 2026](#)
- [Scholarships360 · Top Esports Scholarships April 2026](#)
- [Black Girls Code · Summer Camp 2026](#)
- [iD Tech · Summer Tech Camps & Online Programs](#)
- [Girls Who Code · Summer Programs](#)
- [Code.org · CS Extracurricular Opportunities](#)
- [Spelman College · HBCU Game Jam](#)
- [GamerEd Initiative](#)
- [Cxmmunity Foundation · Opportunities](#)
- [IndieCade Game Educators Summit 2026](#)
- [WUNC · HBCUs use video games to increase diversity in esports](#)
- [AIAS Foundation Scholarships](#)
- [GGP Initiatives](#)
- [GGP x Take-Two DEI page](#)
- [Collegiate Games Challenge · official site](#)
- [GGP/Raw Thrills award \\$90K to students in CGC · GamesBeat](#)
- [Meet the Three GGP Scholars · ESA Foundation Medium](#)
- [Dignitas GGP Scholarship Program](#)
- [Games for Change Our Team / Board](#)
- [GGJ x G4C launch student game jam initiatives · Pixelkin](#)
- [GGP at Global Game Jam 2026](#)
- [IGNITE Impact Challenge 2026](#)

- [GGP Scholars Content YouTube playlist](#) · 4-video flagship public asset, including "The 2K Experience | GGP at GDC '24"